

The De-school BRIGADE

Disillusioned by formal education, parents are choosing to school their children at home so that their natural evolution is not stifled by the traditional system

By Malini Bhupta

The irony that India's educational system has come to be today is best told through the story of an education entrepreneur, R. Satya Narayanan, founder of Career Launcher. This IIM alumnus makes a living out of preparing over 80,000 students a year for competitive exams, and yet he chooses to school his daughter at home. What makes it even more interesting is that his company also runs experimental schools called Indus World School. Despite this, Narayanan has vetoed formal schooling as a mode to attain knowledge.

Not sending children to school may seem blasphemous to a vast majority of Indians, but many are charting a new course for their children's holistic development. They are not scared of dumping convention and experimenting with a format which may seem alien today but is a time-tested model of self-development. Just the way the falling apple propelled Isaac Newton write the universal law of gravity, scores of parents believe that their children will evolve better without the regimented structure of formal schooling. People are so hooked to the formal schooling system that the holistic evolution of the child is no longer the core purpose of education.

Critics of the modern-day curricula claim that the present form of education is merely programmed to churn out people who can function

like assembly lines. But the world has moved on from an industrial age to the information age, which requires people to think differently. Explains Narayanan: "Formal schooling is merely 100 years old and our schooling system was programmed to impart education to the elite who could work as clerks during the British Raj. Education should respond to the individual needs of a child."

Some courageous parents across India are choosing to take a different path and focus on the unique capabilities of their children and allowing them to flower without the stress that modern-day schools create. While for some, the idea of regimentation and the trauma of exams is



Academic competence can be taught at home but parents need to be very disciplined themselves.

NITYA RAMASWAMY, Head, Child Development and Academics, Zee Learning



John and Urmila Samson, 49 & 47 Pune

They believe that formal education may stifle their children's natural evolution. Their three children learn at home and according to their fancy; there is no structured format.

By not putting children through formal education, their capabilities come to the fore better.

URMILA SAMSON

repugnant, others believe that they can do a better job than most schools. Known as home schoolers or the de-schoolers, these families are charting their own unique course in their quest for personal growth as they believe academic competence is a very small part of learning.

For instance, Urmila and John Samson of Pune don't believe in formal education at all. Urmila insists that her children are not home schooled but de-schooled because she feels that all children have their own inherent capabilities. There is no beginning or end to learning and that's the first lesson she wants her children to learn. So she does not follow any curricula and lets her children follow their own hearts. The proposition of a modern-day family opting to keep their children completely cut off from the mainstream educational system may seem scary but the Samsons